

Data Lakehouse Catalog Reality Check

Databricks and Snowflake are talking a big game. So far, they've given us empty Github repositories and rewrites.

 CHRIS
JUN 27, 2024

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I [began my series](#) on data lakehouse catalogs just last week and the news [keeps rolling in](#). This week, Fivetran announced their [managed data lake service](#), and Onehouse [announced](#) \$35 million in series B funding.

In this post, I want to take a look at [Unity](#) and [Polaris](#), the open source catalogs that [Databricks](#) and [Snowflake](#) recently announced. Both vendors launched their catalogs to great fanfare. Unfortunately, the marketing doesn't yet seem to live up to reality.

Before continuing, readers should know that I owned Tabular shares. I don't have any particular visibility into Databricks or Tabular's product strategy, and I've tried to be as fair as possible in this post.

Snowflake has produced a great [product landing page](#) and [blog post](#). I naively assumed that the project was, in fact, released—they link to a Github repo. A friend recently asked me, “Yes, but have you looked at the code?” This is [the code](#).

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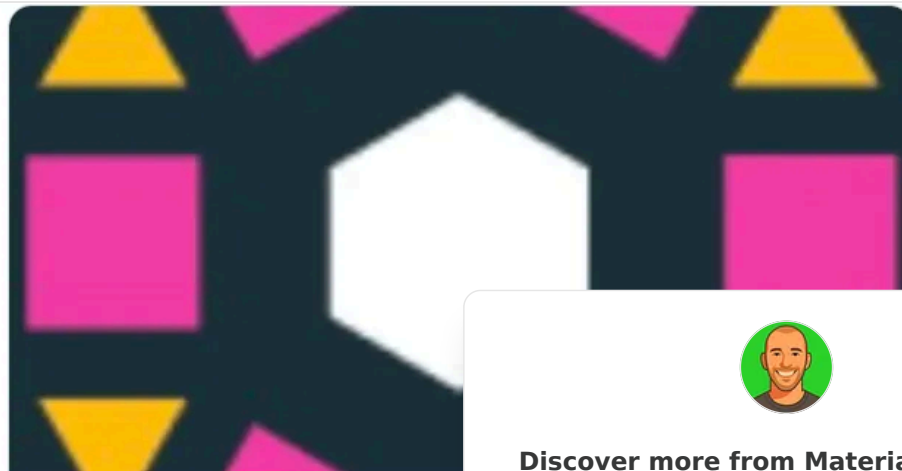
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On further inspection, Snowflake's blog post does mention that developers should watch the Github repository to be notified when the code is released. I missed this. But I expected a bit more here, especially given the amount of marketing copy they've invested in.

Very quickly afterwards, Databricks announced Unity. Again, I was quite excited.



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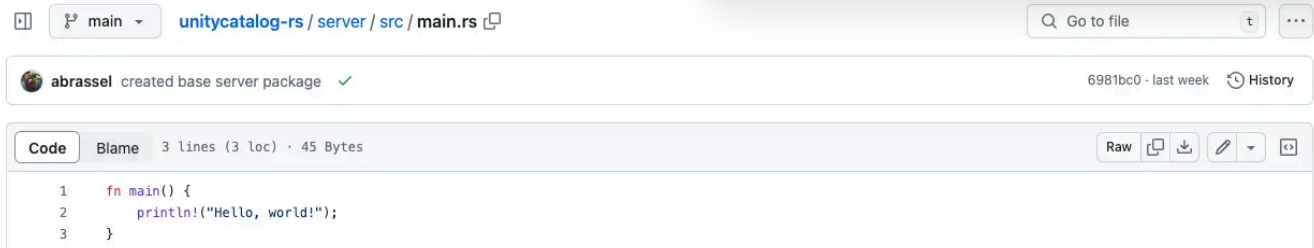
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My excitement has waned. As it turns out, Unity is not Unity. Data product. And it sounds like it's missing quite a bit. Sem Sinchen

At the time of this writing, Unitycatalog looks more like a product. There are no audit capabilities, no external RDBMS persistent storage, currently missing. Big questions were raised about the lack of

Shortly after all of this, I came across unity-rs. Yes, we've now got explains why it needs to exist. I don't have a strong position on the

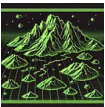


Deja vu. Out of all of these announcements, all this marketing, and all this noise, we've gotten one partial re-write, one empty Github project, and one hello world Rust file.

All of this bothers me a lot less than it used to. I believe unity-rs will get written, that Polaris will be released, and that Databricks will invest in Unity. In Databricks's defense, it's often hard to extricate internal projects. A rewrite is often the right move.

But it's pretty strange to watch all of this play out. It appears the vendors have gotten ahead of themselves. I'm not even sure they all understand why they're open sourcing these projects. I'd love to see someone write down their data lakehouse strategy, or at least do a better job of communicating what the end state of all this is. Right now it looks like flailing.

Other posts in this series are available here:



Make Lakehouse Catalogs Boring Again

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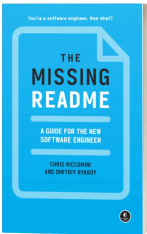
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